

The attacks at the Pentagon on 9/11



Interviewer: Ethan Kennedy

Interviewee: Gary Helminski

Instructor: David Brandt

Date: February 21st, 2024

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Oral History Project Interviewer Release Form

I, Ethan Kennedy, am a participant in the American Century Project. I understand that the purpose of the American Century Project is to collect audio- and video-recorded oral histories as part of a class project. The documentary materials that include a bound copy of the transcript and supporting materials, interview tapes and recordings and visual image of my museum exhibition may be deposited in the permanent collections of the St. Andrew's Episcopal School library. The deposited documentary materials will serve as a record of individual experiences and may be used for scholarly and educational purposes. I understand that responsibility for reproduction, distribution, display, and the creation of derivative works will be at the discretion of the librarian, archivist and/or project coordinator. I also understand that the tapes and transcripts may be used in public presentations including, but not limited to, books, audio and video documentaries, Power Point presentations, exhibitions, articles, public performance, or presentation on the World Wide Web at the project's web site www.documentinghistory.org and on-line archive (www.digitalmaryland.org) or successor technologies.

I hereby grant to St. Andrew's Episcopal School and library ownership of the physical property delivered to the library and the right to use the property that is the product of my participation (for example my interview and additional written materials, photographs) as stated above. By giving permission, I understand that I do not give up any copyright or performance rights that I may hold.

I also grant the St. Andrew's Episcopal School library and project coordinator my absolute and irrevocable consent for any photograph(s) provided by me or taken of me in the course of the my participation in the American Century Project to be used, published, and copied by the St. Andrew's Episcopal School library and its assignees in any medium.

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Accepted and Agreed

ERK

Signature of Interviewer/Student

2/14/24

Date

Ethan Kennedy

Type or Print Name

5119, Baltimore Ave

Address

[Signature]

Signature of Parent or Guardian (if interviewer is a minor)

2/18/24

Date

Patricia Vercelli

Type or Print Name of Parent or Guardian



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American Century Oral History Project Interviewee Release Form

I, GARY HELMINSKI, hereby give and grant to St. Andrew's
(interviewee)
Episcopal School the absolute and unqualified right to the use of my oral history memoir conducted by
Ethan on _____. I understand that
(student interviewer) (date)

the purpose of this project is to collect audio- and video-recorded oral histories of first-hand memories of a particular period or event in history as part of a classroom project (The American Century Project).

I understand that these interviews (recordings and transcripts) will be deposited in the Saint Andrew's Episcopal School library and archives for the use by future students, educators and researchers.

Responsibility for the creation of derivative works will be at the discretion of the librarian, archivist and/or project coordinator. I also understand that the recordings and transcripts may be used in public are limited to St. Andrew's School's internal use, and not for public use or record

~~presentations including, but not limited to, books, audio or video documentaries, slide-tape presentations, exhibits, articles, public performance, or presentation on the World Wide Web at the project's web site~~

~~www.americancenturyproject.org and on-line archive (www.mdch.org) or successor technologies.~~

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~~as well as my right, title and interest in any copyright related to this oral history interview which may be~~

~~secured under the laws now or later in force and effect in the United States of America. This gift, however,~~

~~does not preclude any use that I myself want to make of the information in these transcripts and recordings.~~

~~I herein warrant that I have not assigned or in any manner encumbered or impaired any of the~~
~~forementioned rights in my oral memoir. The only conditions which I place on this unrestricted gift are:~~

1. the oral interviews are not for public record or presentation
2. For internal school use only

Gary Helminski
Signature of Interviewee/Donor

GARY. HELMINSKI
Type or Print Name

3101 ROLLING ROAD
Address

CHRY CHASE, MD
20915

2/19/2024
Date

Statement of Purpose

The purpose of this Oral History interview with Gary John Helminski is to collect and preserve a primary source account of the attacks on the Pentagon on 9/11. By reading the contents of this project that converges evidence from multiple sources, one will gain background knowledge about Al Qaeda, the general security of the United States, and lastly the timeline and description of the attack on the Pentagon.

Biography



Mr. Gary John Helminski was born in November 1954 in Glen Cove, Long Island. He lived with his brother and parents, the traditional family with his father working on building upkeep and repairs at a commercial bakery.

At the same time, his mother stayed home taking care of him and his brother. He was interested in architecture from a young age due to the influence of his father. He attended The Rhode Island School of Design and later got his master's degree in real estate from New York University.

Gary has 35 years of experience as an architect and later was tasked with renovating the five wedges that made up the Pentagon one of which was completed before the attacks. He got married in 2011 and has had two boys Holden and Hudson He is a loving and hard-working father who is now interested in athletics and raising his two boys.

Context Paper

On one fateful day in the year 2001 on September 11th at 8:45 am American Airlines Flight 11 hit the North Tower erupting the world into panic and terror and leaving America vulnerable to the wrath of United Flight 175 and American Airlines Flight 77 heading towards the south tower and the pentagon. Al Qaeda had planned these attacks for years so many signs had occurred before the date of September 11th like the idea of militant Islam or the decline in the United States awareness and the increase in their blind vulnerability which led about 3000 people to die many questions are asked why wasn't anything done or how would the United States not have known about the possibility of an attack from Islamic extremists who sought revenge for their people. Yet another idea is why they would attack these specific buildings and what exactly unfolded on that day. To understand the September 11th attacks one must examine the religion, radicalism, government, and measures taken by both sides as well as gain a first-hand perspective from someone who was there at the time of the attacks at the Capitol.

The ever-evolving conflict and interference in the Middle East were on the rise and Men and Women were growing sick of the US and its involvement in Middle Eastern society. A man that Goes by the name of Osama Bin Laden was the man behind

the famous Al Qaeda organization Firstly one must learn about the mastermind Osama Bin Laden and the backstory of Al Qaeda. Born in 1957, the son of a Wealthy Saudi businessman when Osama was 22 years old the Soviets invaded Afghanistan so Osama financially supported the Islamic resistance to their fight against the Soviets. When the Soviets withdrew from Afghanistan in 1988 then Osama shortly after founded Al Qaeda which at the time was to continue the holy war or jihad through violence against the so-called enemies of the Middle East. During the early years of Al Qaeda, the organization began raising enough money to begin setting up training camp for its militants and providing military support and intel for other Middle Eastern in countries such as Afghanistan and Pakistan, at this time Al Qaeda was also taking violent actions such as bombings and other forms of attacks against other nations.¹ When Al Qaeda was making its presence more known Osama was becoming more known to the US intelligence and in return Osama began despising the United States for their involvement in Afghanistan such as base camps and unnecessary military presence.

not only Osama and Al Qaeda felt this way most people in countries such as Pakistan, Afghanistan, And Saudi Arabia felt the impact of Western involvement

¹ ——. "Osama Bin Laden." FBI.gov. <https://www.fbi.gov/history/famous-cases/osama-bin-laden>.

due to the Struggle to find work, the general feeling of struggle, and corruption however Osama's view of the US was that it was his society's only problem and it was the root cause of their struggles which grew his hatred towards the West even more. In early 1990 Osama moved Al Qaedas operations to Sudan in hopes of having a better chance At training and upkeeping Al Qaeda at this time², Osama was planning to attack the United States with Al Qaeda's new idea of the Islamic idea of Jihad which is to stop the enemies of Islam in whatever way necessary even through violence. Al Qaedas's interpretation of Islam was a key factor in the influence of the 911 attacks. Osama had misinterpreted the idea of Islam and used as a rebound and a reason for their radical ideas and this considered them Islamic militants. Militant Islam is not the same as Islam and its obscured and violent other option was the one Osama was using. Osama became so powerful in Saudi Arabia due to people seeing him as a hero of the people and was fully supported by the citizens due to his promises to increase the economy and make it better by removing foreign influence which controlled the economy. However, the Saudi government did not see Osama as a savior but instead as a threat they denied the involvement of Al Qaeda in the Iraq invasion and Osama became angry at the Saudi government because they relied on the United States further increasing Osama's hatred of the US. Al Qaeda's first major and significant attack on the US was in 1993 when a few of Al Qaedas terrorists with the main planner named Ramzi Yousef put a bomb in a

² ——. "Osama Bin Laden." FBI.gov. <https://www.fbi.gov/history/famous-cases/osama-bin-laden>.

truck parked in the Garages underneath the World Trade Center planning to collapse

the buildings from the bottom failed to collapse however it killed six and left others wounded. This attack revealed To investigators that other famous landmarks would also be bombed in ³the attacks, the arrest of Ramzi Yousef led his uncle the very important Khalid Sheik Mohammed to join Al Qaeda. In 1996 Osama moved Al Qaeda back to Afghanistan where he made an Alliance with the Taliban government to make a safe place for him to train his men and plan attack.⁴ Leading up to 911 Al Qaeda made their presence more known by attacking more things linked to the US, 3 years before 911 Al Qaeda bombed US embassies in Kenya and Tanzania killing 200 Americans and having Osama gain charges of conspiring against the US. These attacks had finally made enough of an impact to make the US issue several anit-terror units in 1999 however after these attacks Osama Bin Laden was put onto the US's most wanted list making Al Qaeda more of a threat and it was shown as time passed through Al Qaedas failures in attacks⁵. The last large attack before 911 made by Al Qaeda was the bombing of the USS Cole on October 12th, 2000 suicide bombers steered a small boat into the vessel killing 17 and wounding many others. Know that Al Qaeda was very known to the US the reason 911 and other

³ ——. "Osama Bin Laden." FBI.gov. <https://www.fbi.gov/history/famous-cases/osama-bin-laden>.

⁴ ——. "Osama Bin Laden." FBI.gov. <https://www.fbi.gov/history/famous-cases/Osama-bin-laden>.

⁵ Huiskes, Katherine. "TIMELINE: THE SEPTEMBER 11 TERRORIST ATTACKS." Millercenter UVA. <https://millercenter.org/remembering-september-11/september-11-terrorist-attacks>.

terrorist attacks were so easy was mostly because of weak support of anti-terror in the US government, the FBI and CIA attempted to investigate the terror attacks however there wasn't enough support financially. ⁶The US government had no chance against Al Qaeda their highly advanced planning and smart decision-making even confused the US however the government never thought Al Qaeda was capable of such attacks so therefore they never thought an attack as extreme could happen on US soil. The government simply wasn't focused on anti-terror and the Bush administration neither cared and left Al Qaeda in the hands of the FBI and CIA which didn't have the funds to investigate. Another issue with leaving anti-terror in the hands of the CIA and FBI is that these ⁷organizations were better at homeland security instead of international and even efforts were made in 2000 to strengthen these organizations' research capabilities however the Clinton administration wasn't very effective in maintaining the promise. Lastly, the FAA's lack of security was a major issue for airports not much could be done to improve security and many changes were lackluster in preventing such attacks. Security was not much of a concern for the FAA again with the idea that nothing would ever happen and also many rules of what one can and can't take on a plane were much more relaxed meaning prohibited items could be taken on a plane.

Specific Context:

⁶ Editors of Encyclopedia Britannica, ed. "Attacks on USS Cole." Encyclopedia Britannica. <https://www.britannica.com/event/USS-Cole-attack>.

⁷ Huiskes, Katherine. "TIMELINE: THE SEPTEMBER 11 TERRORIST ATTACKS." Millercenter UVA. <https://millercenter.org/remembering-september-11/september-11-terrorist-attacks>.

My interviewee Gary John Helminski witnessed the events that took place on September 11th, 2001 at the Pentagon in Washington DC as a contractor working on the property, At 8:20 am September 11th Flight 77 took off from Dulles airport and headed for Los Angeles California. The flight had 53 passengers, 6 crew members, and 36,000 pounds of fuel, the flight was likely taken over at 8:53 am by 5 Al Qaeda militants. ⁸The man in charge of flying the plane into the Pentagon was Hani Hanjour who had earned his commercial pilot license from Arizona training at the CRM airline center after he earned his license he returned to Saudi Arabia. It was thought that Hanjour had made contact with other militants in the Arizona area. After the nationwide ground stop of aircraft at 9:27 am Flight 77 is missing the FAA is struggling to communicate with other officials about the situation.⁹ At 9:37 am AA Flight 77 hit the Pentagon at the west side E ring first level between the 4th and 5th corridor and the destruction ended between the C and B ring of the building, the portion of the building that was hit collapsed. All passengers on board immediately died and 184 people were killed in the impact and destruction to the Pentagon's west side

¹⁰while the entirety of the building was taken

DC watched as over by flames

⁸Natiional Commision on terrori Report, Doc., at 585 (July 22, 911Report.pdf.

⁹ Natiional Commision on terror Report, Doc., at 585 (July 22, 911Report.pdf.

¹⁰ Natiional Commision on terro Report, Doc., at 585 (July 22, 911Report.pdf.



and smoke similar to the ones in newyork. Immediate attempts to rescue victims followed even through the confusion of the surrounding populous due to everyone being unsure what exactly had happened and the erupting building fire and smoke which was hard to put out because of its sheer size since most thought a bomb went off or a shooting it wasn't people's first idea that a plane had hit the Pentagon. Passengers aboard Flight 93 which was supposedly going to hit the capitol learned of the other hijackings that took place which were the Pentagon and the World Trade Centers ¹¹however the Pentagon was the biggest reason, the passengers launched a counterattack on the cockpit of Flight 93 which the hijackers crashed the plane into a field in Pennsylvania. Pentagon officials had known about the attacks at the World Trade Center but it had been too late for the defense of the Pentagon since ¹²no fighter jets had attempted to take down the aircraft so most officials had realized that they were a target next after hearing its engines from a distance. News coverage of the Pentagon attacks was everywhere all over the world. The newspaper the Potomac News gave insight into the Attacks in New York and mostly the Pentagon which made the news of the attack much more public for people who didn't have television at the time. This newspaper wanted to

¹¹Transportation Security Administration
Transportation security timeline. L
<https://www.tsa.gov/>

timeline#:~:text=Created%20in%20th
%202001.

¹²library of congress blogs. Last modi
14, 2023. <https://blogs.loc.gov/hea>
september-11-2001-20-years-later-



November%2019%2C
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show the urgency and terrifying reality of the states of the country by using yellow journalism to drag in viewers with a concerning title which helped the companies who wrote newspapers however it drew a more realistic view of the Pentagon attacks making the Pentagon as significant as New York. This other news paper has the same idea of spreading the word to everyone about 911 however this newspaper is directed towards both the New York attacks and the Pentagon. Many different news sources at this time including newspapers used the term “scale of Pearl Harbor” which was the last major terroristic attack on the use back in 1939 which is a very bold idea that many Americans at the time and to this day agree on that this one day 23 years ago had the same significance as a pre worldwar bombing.¹³ The aftermath of 911 had many effects on the nature of our country so immediately after 911 President Bush initiated war on terror in Iraq and Afghanistan to take revenge and to shut Al Qaeda and eventually take down Osama Bin Laden 10 years after when Seal Team Six invaded his home and killed him which was thought to be the end of Al Qaeda. The war in Afghanistan and Iraq continued for many years after its ¹⁴initial response 20 years ago. Some more effects of 911 are health and structural issues in surrounding buildings in new york and the Pentagon itself with its officials being hurt during the attacks. The most common and significant daily life change was the invention of the TSA and the tightening of security measures in airports and on aircraft, the TSA was signed by President Bush on November 19th, 2001

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¹⁴ Huiskes, Katherine. "TIMELINE: THE SEPTEMBER 11 TERRORIST ATTACKS." Millercenter UVA. <https://millercenter.org/remembering-september-11/september-11-terrorist-attacks>.

after it being issued by Congress which created harsher screening procedures and more security measures to be implemented so something like this would not happen again. Lastly the government changed its communication between agencies and created the department of homeland security which increased national surveillance of money laundering which does interrupt terrorist communications.¹⁵¹⁶¹⁷

Historians have interpreted 911 in many ways however there is a theme of people not taking it seriously whether its the government or regular people some just seem to remain the same even after such a horrific thing had happened and that it was enjoyable to recollect what had happened through their perspective. Some historians interpreted 911 as a change in how the US has relationships with other countries and within itself. Some Cultural changes such as racism towards middle eastern citizens due to they're from or radical racism is seen to be interpreted from different books. Sandhya Shukla an english professor who taught a course about 911 has changed her opinions on the event and the

¹⁵ Huiskes, Katherine. "TIMELINE: THE SEPTEMBER 11 TERRORIST ATTACKS." Millercenter UVA. <https://millercenter.org/remembering-september-11/september-11-terrorist-attacks>.

¹⁶ library of congress blogs. Last modified September 11, 2021. Accessed November 14, 2023. <https://blogs.loc.gov/headlinesandheroes/2021/09/september-11-2001-20-years-later-a-remembrance-in-newspapers/>.

¹⁷ library of congress blogs. Last modified September 11, 2021. Accessed November 14, 2023. <https://blogs.loc.gov/headlinesandheroes/2021/09/september-11-2001-20-years-later-a-remembrance-in-newspapers/>.

effects however in her closing remark about culture she states “I do think 9/11 and the cultural responses to it can help us think about other crises of nationality and globality” which means the way people responded to middle eastern and other parts of the world. Looking at the more positive light of the aftermath by historian Larry Sabato on the political and patriotic unity the US had after 9/11 he states the Bush lost the popular vote and became very controversial however he says “in many ways reunited the American people” which means that there was a force of patriotism similar to Pearl Harbor, this unity which was unheard of made Bush win the popular vote 91% which was the first of its kind in US history, the problem with the unity generated was that it covered up the issues the US was facing and even up to this day

¹⁸In conclusion the reason the attack at the pentagon and my interviewees story are important and why you should care is because the attacks led many things to happen which are important to this day some of which are the change in cultural and social dynamic creating unity among Americans and challenging the idea of prejudice, racism, and discrimination creating a better environment for our country to thrive. Another reason is the change in relationships with other countries through military and government creating a stronger country. Lastly it is important for the future to adapt to new environments and to make sure nothing like it can happen again. ¹⁹

¹⁸ Newman, Caroline. "What 9/11 Changed: Reflecting on the Cultural Legacy of the Attacks, 20 Years on." University of Virginia. Last modified July 30, 2021. <https://news.virginia.edu/content/what-911-changed-reflecting-cultural-legacy-attacks-20-years>.

¹⁹ Sonwaru, Lindsey. "9/11 at Pentagon." Digital Maryland. Last modified February 11, 2019. <https://collections.digitalmaryland.org/digital/collection/saac/id/53917/rec/1>.

Oral History Transcription
Interviewee: Gary John Helminski
Interviewer: Ethan Kennedy
Date: January 11th, 2024
Location: Zoom call

Ethan Kennedy: Alright I'm Ethan and I'm interviewing Gary Helminski and alright let's start, first question what was it like growing up in the 1950s and 60's around the area you lived in?

Gary Helminski: So I grew up in a small town when I was about six or seven we moved from Long Island to New Jersey and grew up on a sort of an Archie Bunker kinda block, middle class, lots of houses packed right against each other, had an older brother who was seven years older than me so, yea and I didn't really play that much cause there was such a big age difference but I had lots of friends up and down the street where I lived and where I went to school which is about six or seven blocks away so I walked to school every morning and came home for lunch, had lunch at home went back to school, and went to high school a long way away had to take a bus everyday to high school and you know it was pretty you know middle-class semi-suburban, urban life so it was all good.

EK: Alright and what did your parents do for a living?

GH: My dad was a operating engineer, he maintained all the building systems air conditioning, heating, plumbing all that kind of thing, and just kept the building operating and running which is probably where a little bit of my inspiration came for being an architect and my mom was mostly a stay at home mom, took care of the kids and that was it.

EK: And what building did your father take care of and maintain?

GH: It was a factory, it was a, it was a - large factory that's actually a very large commercial bakery it was probably the size of a football field and it had two stories and it made baked products for a major supermarket chain in the New York - New Jersey metropolitan area.

EK: All right, and this you might have already answered some of this, but were you always interested in becoming an architect or a contractor?

GH: No, no, I was always interested in the arts, in drawing and painting and photography and all that, and eventually went to design school to be a photographer and after about a year, I decided that's not what I wanted to do. And I transferred into the architectural program and received my Bachelor of Fine Arts and Bachelor of Architecture.

EK: OK and what made you decide to choose? Well, you might answer what made you decide to choose architecture as a course of study.

GH: Well, I knew there was someone that was a family friend who was an architect. And I admired him and I admired the work that he did. He was an architect for smaller projects, residential homes, some churches, synagogues, things like that. So I was just impressed by him and what he did for a living, and it compared to photography, I like the idea that it was something that was real, that you could feel, touch, walk in, it felt more, long-lasting and permanent than taking a picture.

EK: Right and why did you choose to work at the Pentagon for the project?

GH: Well, I didn't, I didn't exactly choose it what happened was I was working for a large architecture, engineering, construction management firm. And we competed to the term is to be program managers, to oversee the renovation of the Pentagon. And as program managers, we hire the architects, the engineers, the general contractors, and I did that for 5 years. It was my, my primary responsibility and we had most of the time over 100 people working on that project directly kind of under me, but then in addition to that, there were, you know, general contractors that we managed and so it's a long-term project and it was even over the five years that I worked on it. There were only a few pieces that we that we, that I had responsibility for completing because it was a very slow process, new heating and refrigeration plant, a new mail delivery facility, and the Pentagon is the largest office building in the world. It's six million square feet,

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and each wedge it's divided into five wedges, thus the term Pentagon, which means five-sided, each wedge is about 1.2 million square feet, so at the time that 9/11 happened, we had only finished completing and renovating one wedge, which is where the plane hit, and fortunately, it was largely unoccupied at the time because it wasn't completely finished and people hadn't moved in. So it was, if they were going to hit the Pentagon with a plane, it was exactly the right place to hit it. Isn't ____+ was hardly anybody in it.

EK: Interesting, and how did you feel about the security in the United States at the time prior to the 9/11 attacks?

GH: Oh, I thought it was fine, I mean, you know, nobody would have imagined what happened on 9/11, you know, it was basically people that converted airplanes into flying bombs and were willing to sacrifice their own life to do what they did, so it was a, it was a paradigm shift, nobody, nobody really even thought that anything like that could or would happen, so it was a shocking event.

EK: All right. What was a typical day like working ah, at the Pentagon was there like a lot of security or.?

GH: Well we, we had a, we had a kind of a compound that was outside of the Pentagon, I was, I did not work in the Pentagon I worked adjacent to it in a series of temporary trailers, basically construction trailers. So that's where our, most of our workforce was,

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was in the trailers, not in the Pentagon, but I did have a top-secret security clearance. I went into the Pentagon frequently, but day to day, most of my time was in the construction trailers, not in the actual Pentagon building itself.

EK: And in that trailer, did you... like have plans or, could you, like, see the Pentagon from a distance, or how?

GH: Yeah, yeah. There were windows and we could see the Pentagon. It was, it wasn't far. It was, I walked out of those trailers, it was, you know, with, within three, four or five minutes, I could be at the door of the Pentagon.

EK: OK, the attacks on the World Trade Center happened like an hour before the actual attack on the Pentagon. Did you hear about those attacks? and if you did what was your reaction? and did you think that they would target the Pentagon?

GH: I'd heard about the attacks. I mean, the first, the first plane that hit the first tower. Everyone, I think there was an assumption that it was just an accident and it wasn't intentional. It was just some wacky person ran a plane into the Pentagon (World Trade Center), but then after the second one hit then there was a concern that there was, we were all vulnerable. And I don't even remember the time between the, when the plane hit the Pentagon, between the planes that hit the World Trade Center, but nobody was anticipating that you know, the Pentagon was a target, so there was no particular lockdown or, you know y what do you call it just getting people out of the building, I

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mean, that, that, that never occurred. There was never any concern that the Pentagon was going to be the next target for this.

EK: Right. But you, you, at the time before the Pentagon got hit, you had heard about?

GH: Yea

EK: Ok

GH: Yes, we have. We had. We were aware of it. Yeah.

EK: Where were you at well, the flight hit at 9:37 am where?

GH: I was in the trailer. I was in the construction trailer.

EK: Okay, and you, oh sorry

GH: ____ + No, I mean, I was there and heard the explosion. Or the explosion and went running out from the trailer and, you know saw the explosion and fire and just see the crash into the side of the building.

EK: Did you ever think that you would be in a situation seeing that?

GH: No

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EK: Yea

GH: No, no, not in a million years.

EK: Alright what was it like hearing the explosion and seeing the smoke before you approached,

GH: Well, just shock, just shock, just shock and, you know, pretty much assume that this was another target, associated with the planes that crashed into the into the towers in New York.

EK: you said you had known about it. So at that point, you had known. The Pentagon was one of those targets, right?

GH: No, we didn't know the Pentagon was a target. We had no idea. We didn't know until the plane hit the building. Although, no.

EK: All right what was it like to see the Pentagon where you were working be attacked and partially destroyed? Like that progress?

GH: It was just shocking. It was just absolutely shocking like probably anybody just stunned, stunned as anybody would have been to hear that the Pentagon basically had been attacked through via a plane basically crashing into the side of the building. But again I think a key takeaway in all this is it was the only section of the Pentagon that had been renovated and part of the renovation was, we made the exterior walls of the building three feet thick with concrete to help resist any kind of bomb or explosions and then all of the life safety systems in that wedge were operate, state of the art operational, so all the sprinklers and fire protection systems all went on and helped kind of dissipate the fire and again, there were very few people in that building. So instead of the 230 or something people that died because there were some people that were in the building, but not very many ordinarily, there would have been 5000 people in that wedge, not 250. So the loss of life would have likely been even greater than the World Trade Center.

EK: Interesting and did you think that Al Qaeda had known about these renovations?

GH: No I mean, I have no idea, Ethan, but I don't think so if they did, they would have hit a different section of the building that was occupied. I think they had no idea what was going on because they hit exactly the part of the building that had the least impact in terms of killing people if they were smart they would have known what was going on and they would have hit a different section of the building.

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EK: All right and did you think that the plane had hit or did you assume like a bomb had gone off I mean, did you know it was a plane?

GH: I didn't know it was a plane and I didn't see any evidence that It was a plane. It was as if the plane vaporized there was no, I didn't see any wings, any tail section, and then some people that I saw who claimed that they saw the plane hit said that it was a small corporate jet-sized plane it wasn't a big airliner So, I don't, It's still a mystery to me what happened that day.

EK: All right and what happened after you saw the building on fire? I mean, what did, what was the immediate, like, aftermath?

GH: Well, we were in no position, we just had to stay away I mean, the Arlington County, Alexandria Fire Department all the emergency vehicles came and we were just told to go home, just stay away, let the professionals do the rescue work so, we all left.

EK: Alright, how did you feel, like following the attacks?

GH: Probably like any citizen I was just amazed and shocked and couldn't believe it happened.

EK: Did you?

GH: Like the rest of the United States.

EK: Right did you like, how did you feel about like the security and integrity of the U.S. after the attacks?

GH: Well, it became apparent that there was no intelligence around this because we didn't know it was going to happen and that we were a lot more vulnerable than we thought and just a new methodology for how collectively we or anybody could be attacked, nevermind just the United States, anybody. That some people turned commercial airliners into flying bombs no one, no one had anticipated something like that happening.

EK: All right.

GH: You know, there was never any real significant security at airports. You could walk onto a plane there was no scanning for weapons or anything like that. It's part of how these individuals got through they were carrying box cutters and that was their weapons whatever they could get on the plane.

EK: All right

GH: I'm by no means an expert on everything 9-11. I just happened to be at the Pentagon that day.

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EK: All right, okay did you have any assumptions about who had committed the attacks?

GH: No, not at the time no, no idea neither did anybody else haha.

EK: All right and did you feel that the culture and social dynamic had changed after the attacks, like racism or like patriotism?

GH: I think maybe it brought people together a little bit in the country maybe some patriotism, maybe some race racism too once they figured out that it was Osama bin Laden and his clan but yeah

EK: All right

GH: I think the country kind of came together and there was more, maybe initially more suspicion about Arab or Islamic people.

EK: Did you like, have any opinions about the Arabs or like terrorists at the time or now?

GH: No, no

EK: All right.

GH: Not really I mean there are bad people everywhere I didn't necessarily think, paint every Arab or person is Islamic person with a broad brush like they're all bad. I lived in the Middle East for a couple of years so I knew the people in the culture very well. No, I didn't think all of a sudden these are bad people I think there were, there were some bad eggs in that basket that's all. Some people were up to no good I don't think it necessarily reflected on Islam or the Arab culture.

EK: Okay and did your life change career-wise after the attacks?

GH: Well, I was on my way leaving that firm that I was working for, so it was really kind of the end of my employment so I had already decided I was going to leave. So that was kind of the end of an era for me working for that company.

EK: So that one event was just kind of the?

GH: Well, the decision had already been made. That event had nothing to do with my decision to leave it just was coincidental that I was only gonna be working for that firm for i don't know another month or so, and then I was gone and the people that I left behind still had responsibility for the project so they were the folks that basically had the responsibility to rebuild the Pentagon. Which was done by the team that I left behind I could have been part of that, but I had already made a decision to move on.

EK: Okay and last question do you still revisit the the Pentagon? Ideas or the memories you experienced that day?

GH: No, no, no like flashbacks or just reminiscing about that day. Not unless somebody brings it up and asks me about it but in general no. The further I can keep that away from my mind, the better there's nothing really pleasant or nothing great about the memory.

EK: Alright.

GH: Okay?

EK: Alright well

GH: Are we good?

EK: We are

GH: 22-minute mark of zoom recording

Zoom Link:

<https://saes.zoom.us/j/96287077400?pwd=VkpQZDA2aWlNbmt4WWdWaFlxelB1dz09>

Audio time 5 minutes - Gary Helminski's backstory through childhood, family, and his Reason for becoming an architect.

Audio time 5 minutes (10 minutes in) - He discussed the structure of the Pentagon, the Security of the US, his role in construction, and what his reaction was to the initial attack in New York.

Audio time 5 minutes (15 minutes in) - He discussed everyone he was around initial reaction to the attacks, the structure itself, what made up the Pentagon, description of Loss of life, and lastly the plane description

Audio time 5 minutes (20 minutes in) - he describes How he felt after the attacks on that day, The integrity of the US, how they had no anticipation of the attacks, what he had noticed the changes to the US, and lastly what racial standpoint was taken through the attacks.

Interview Analysis

Oral history is a type of historical recollection that occurs in the form of audio and video recordings of events or people, but also personal interviews with people who experienced an event firsthand. Some examples of oral history are videos on interviews on YouTube in which the interviewee explains their personal experience. There are also audio recordings such as podcasts which have questions about a subject being asked to one who went through an event or witnessed it. Oral history is important because not all historical documents are accurate and can leave out information. It is also important to hear someone's personal story about their specific experience. For example, a war document on World War 1 about the British army experiences is not going to be as accurate as if you were to interview an actual British soldier who actually fought it is the same for Helmski my interviewee having seen the attacks and can give specific insight to what he saw. Oral history is separate from other forms of history due to its need for interviews through video or audio along with the most important part the specificity of each interviewee's stories. oral history is strong in the sense of getting an upfront understanding of an event and putting yourself in one's shoes. However, some interviewees may not be accurate due to loss of memory or other reasons that could make the information inaccurate.

911 at the Pentagon is my topic. The September 11th attacks on the US by Al Qaeda, an Islamic extremist group that chose to attack the US for revenge and power. I chose

this period because I find these attacks interesting along with it being fascinating.

These attacks did have a lasting impact on the United States as a whole.

My interviewee Gary John Helminski was a witness to the attacks that unfolded that day. He is a family man who enjoys time with his sons and fitness. Helminski is an architect and real estate developer who at the time was tasked with renovating the building wedges since the building was made up of sections or wedges. He was in his construction trailer when the plane hit and he saw the aftermath. We interviewed on a Zoom call and the call was recorded for the interview process. I chose this interviewee because I have known him for a while since he was one of my dad's good friends.

When I found out a few months before the project that he bore witness to this event I had to get an interview the other reason is that I find the topic interesting and it would be easier to communicate and understand Helminski more than someone else for me.

My interviewee seems to not feel strongly about the event other than who he thinks did it or the specifics but prefers not to remember it or think about it since it's just something he's acknowledged and thought about in the past. During the interview, I learned some impactful and new knowledge of the event such as when I brought up the topic of what it was like to see your work be destroyed and attacked, Helminski said, "There were very few people in that building. So instead of the, you know, 230 or something people that died because some people were in the building, but not very many ordinarily, there would have been 5000 people in that wedge, not 250. So the loss of life would have likely been even greater than the World Trade

Center.”[**Kennedy 21**] ²⁰I found this interesting because the timeframe in which these attacks took place was the worst outcome life-wise for Al Qaeda having had 230 to 250 which is important to understand for the broad overview of the impact of the attacks.

Earlier in the interview, He answered my question about why he chose or didn’t choose to work at the Pentagon, saying “It’s six million square feet, and each wedge is divided into five wedges, thus the term Pentagon, which means five-sided, each wedge is about 1.2 million square feet, so at the time that 9/11 happened, we had only finished completing and renovating one wedge, which is where the plane hit, and fortunately, it was largely unoccupied at the time because it wasn’t completely finished.”²¹[**Kennedy 16-17**] The quote is similar to the prior one because both state specifics that I had never known about the Pentagon. The quote or quotes I found interesting are the ones I stated due to how they changed my view, surprised me, and gave me more research information. I struggled to find accurate documentation of the specifics of the Pentagon and what exactly had happened both in and out and this quote helped me understand my research more.

The topics of my research in my context paper and the interview were similar but with different outcomes. For example, the security of the U.S. was very jeopardized at the time before the attacks. However, Helminski did not know the

²⁰ Kennedy, Ethan, and Gary Helminski. "Interview Transcription." Google Docs. Last modified January 15, 2024. <https://docs.google.com/document/d/1DsKnXaGW9SSldxRakEGv84mv7cy42Vfk31KFdv7INzo/edit>.

²¹ Kennedy, Ethan, and Gary Helminski. "Interview Transcription." Google Docs. Last modified January 15, 2024. <https://docs.google.com/document/d/1DsKnXaGW9SSldxRakEGv84mv7cy42Vfk31KFdv7INzo/edit>.

fragility of the U.S. government until after the attacks stating “It became apparent that there was no intelligence around this because we didn't know it was going to happen and that we were a lot more vulnerable than we thought”²²[Kennedy 23]. At the time while in my research I was aware of the issues with the U.S. government. Another way that the context paper was contrasted as previously said was the building itself and the attack site. The federal documents I researched were vague and unsure about the specifics of the Pentagon while Helminski knew and understood what had happened from a ground level. I think the similarities and differences occurred because not everyone is going to know exactly all the broad details of what happened at the same time and his knowing would have affected the answer he gave. This time specifically had misinformation from the government and the people which was typical since the information would be scrambled after an attack and accurate descriptions would take a while to uncover.

My interview is valuable because it shows the true impact of someone who saw the attacks but actually contributed to the documentation of the attacks. This interview is a valuable and reliable source of information about the building itself before, during, and after the attacks. In more ways than one, it differed in information about the building and the attack site, but not so much information about Al Qaeda or the security of the US. I think Helminski did a good job in both contradicting my research and confirming it since it was a half-and-half situation, so I think the interview

²² Kennedy, Ethan, and Gary Helminski. "Interview Transcription." Google Docs. Last modified January 15, 2024. <https://docs.google.com/document/d/1DsKnXaGW9SSldxRakEGv84mv7cy42Vfk31KFdv7INzo/edit>.

confirmed it by applying what I had researched about the rest of the world accurately and helping my interviewee get a broader understanding of where he was but contradicted my research by making it seem inaccurate. Someone listening to or reading my interview would learn new things about the attacks, before the attack on the Pentagon, global, and national issues that caused and or later caused things to happen such as the attack. The historical value of my context paper compared to the historical value of my interview is that my context paper has more information on global and national security events that would collide with the US. These attacks make my context paper a good source of information on the broad details of the attack on the Pentagon. My interview however had much more of a personal and upfront perspective of the attack and gave information on the specifics of the attack. My interview commented on my context paper due to my interview explaining the significance of the future of the US through his perspective rather than on the US as a whole.

As an oral historian, I would have to say it's pretty tasking and challenging for me to find reliable and accurate information on an event that had been over for a long time to try to understand different perspectives whether it was through documents, my interview, or other interview videos I had watched. I would say it paid out in the end with new information and perspectives. In the oral history process, I learned how to write better which is a common outcome, but also analyze documents and recordings better because I got a better understanding of what accurate information looks like which will help me in the future for 12th grade, college, and beyond. The OHP changed my thinking throughout the months we had done it from critical thinking

skills to writing skills, but also analyzing skills which will help me finish the project.

In conclusion, the value given to my context paper was much greater than my research and can make my context paper more accurately depict and specify the events that unfolded on 9/11 while the interview and interviewee had gained information on the topic that combined and created new understanding for both myself and Helmisnki.

The historical value of my OHP is the new sources of information and accurate sources which could make for a better future of documentation on the subject. The historical value and significance of oral history is the specific perspectives on events that can create or destroy information that could represent an event which makes oral history a powerful tool. I think there should be more oral history records so we can understand the first-person perspectives of events better and for more information on such events that would create a better version of history.